

WOWING, WOOING Rahul Gandhi with college students in Nilgiri, TN, Apr. 15

Photographs by ANI

The Caste Net

The Opposition camp is also expecting to influence young voters with its promise of a nationwide caste census and removal of the 50 per cent cap on reservation. It is aimed primarily at the OBC (Other Backward Class) voters who have a 27 per cent share in the reservation pie even though they are believed to constitute more than 50 per cent of the population. In the past two consecutive Lok Sabha polls, more than 50 per cent of the OBC youth have voted for the saffron party, according to the CSDS survey. As reservations directly impact education and employment—two issues important to the youth—the Congress expects its promise of removing the cap on reservations to break the BJP's grip over OBC youth.

Experts, though, are not too optimistic about the appeal of this plank. In the MOTN poll, 57 per cent of the respondents aged between 18 and 24 said reservations should be based on economic, not caste status. "A caste census won't have any resonance among youth voters," says Amitabh Tiwari, political strategist and election analyst. "It did not work even in the Hindi heartland states." The Congress promise also suffers from a trust deficit. In a recently concluded CSDS survey, 36 per cent of the youth (18-25 years) said the Congress and other parties in the INDIA (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance) bloc are using the caste census as a political tool for OBC mobilisation. Only a quarter of the respondents felt that the parties are serious about the issue.

If not jobs and caste, what else is likely to resonate with the youth? The BJP is relying on its tried-and-tested planks of Hindutva and nationalism to attract the youth as well. In the MOTN poll, 23 per cent of the respondents in the 18-24 age group had chosen the building of the Ram mandir in Ayodhya as the biggest achievement of the Modi government, 6 percentage points above the national average. Its effect can be felt in as seemingly unlikely a place as Baharampur in West Bengal, where 25-year-old Sirsha Acharya, a sculptor-cum-painter, says, "The consecration of the Ram temple carries significance beyond religious lines. It has bolstered the economy of the area and strengthened an entire community that was losing its religious identity."

Another perception that the BJP is working hard to cement among the youth is of India's improved global standing, especially after its successful conduct of the G20 presidency. It's evident in the youthspeak. "India is always part of the conversation the world over," says the 21-year-old international archer Ojas Pravin Deotale. Olympics in India in 2036? That should have his vote too. The success of Chandrayaan-3 and the prospect of India becoming the world's third-largest economy are woven in as deftly into the narrative to reinforce national pride and the vision of a Viksit Bharat. Modi and other BJP leaders are talking extensively about the work they have done to build the country's capacity in artificial intelligence, bots, semi-conductors, new-age manufacturing and strengthening the start-up ecosystem. All of which